

ServoraBd

Local Service Marketplace

RENDER DEPLOYMENT RECORD

How this project was put on the internet: the code changes it needed, the two routes that failed, the one that worked, and what is still outstanding.

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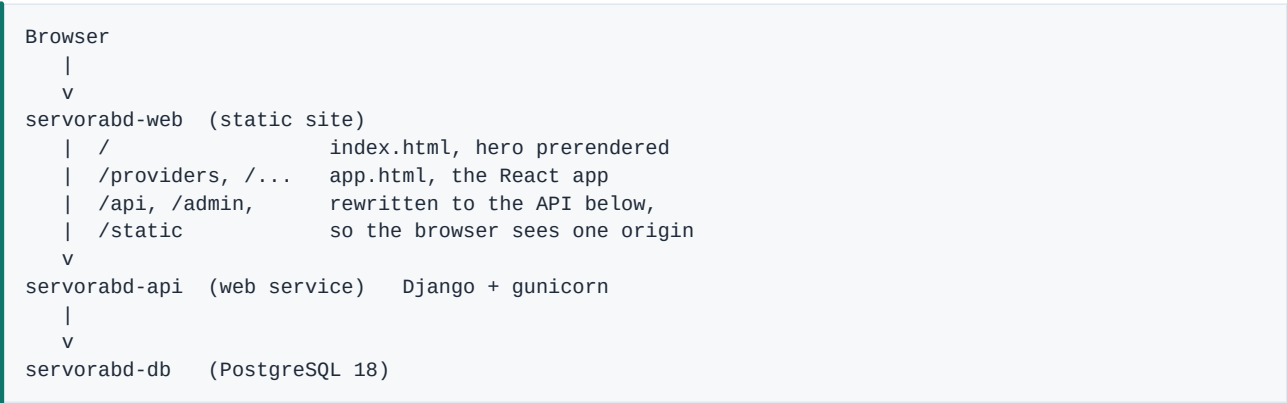
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1. What was deployed

Piece	Address	Plan
Static site	servorabd-web.onrender.com	Free
API	servorabd-api.onrender.com	Free, sleeps when idle
Database	PostgreSQL 18, Singapore	Free, deleted after 30 days

Verified live: /healthz/ returns {"status": "ok", "database": "ok"}, and the site serves 8 categories, 45 services and 38 locations through the API. Deployed from commit 36d4190 on main.

1.1 The shape of it



The browser only ever talks to the static site. It forwards /api, /admin and /static to Django behind the scenes, which is why no CORS configuration was needed anywhere.

2. What had to change in the code

The repository already had a `render.yaml` and deployment notes, but it would not have survived a first deploy. Five things were fixed, all in commit 36d4190.

2.1 The build would have crashed

`config/settings/prod.py` required `EMAIL_HOST`, `EMAIL_HOST_USER`, `EMAIL_HOST_PASSWORD`, `DEFAULT_FROM_EMAIL` and the `S3_*` keys. The blueprint marked every one of them `sync: false`, meaning unset until filled in by hand, so Django raised `ImproperlyConfigured` before serving anything. They now have defaults: with no SMTP the mail backend discards messages instead of refusing to start, and with no bucket the storage backend falls back to local disk.

2.2 The health check could never have passed

`healthCheckPath` pointed at `/api/v1/categories/`, but `SECURE_SSL_REDIRECT` is on, so Render's internal HTTP probe received a 301 and the service would have been marked unhealthy forever. A `/healthz/` endpoint was added — it also runs `SELECT 1` against the database — and exempted from the redirect via `SECURE_REDIRECT_EXEMPT`. Confirmed: `/healthz/` answers 200 over plain HTTP while every other path still returns 301.

2.3 Every request would have returned 400

`ALLOWED_HOSTS` was empty on a fresh deploy. It now falls back to Render's own `RENDER_EXTERNAL_HOSTNAME`, which also feeds `CSRF_TRUSTED_ORIGINS`. This is why no host configuration was needed during the deploy.

2.4 Two smaller fixes

- A `/media/*` rewrite was missing. The dev proxy had one; production did not, so uploaded photos would 404 whenever object storage is off — which is the case on free.
- `WEB_CONCURRENCY` was added. The gunicorn config defaults to 3 workers, which is tight on a 512 MB instance.

2.5 Checked and deliberately left alone

The strict Content-Security-Policy was briefly relaxed for Tailwind, then reverted: the built bundle contains no inline script, no inline style and no runtime stylesheet injection, so `style-src 'self'` holds. The full backend test suite passes with all of the above.

3. Two routes that did not work

Worth recording, because both cost time and neither is obvious.

3.1 Blueprint, first attempt: a schema error

Render rejected `render.yaml` with `field command not found in type file.Service` on the two cron services. Render's cron schema uses `startCommand`, not `command`. Both were fixed and pushed.

3.2 Blueprint, second attempt: a demand for a card

With the schema valid, Render asked for payment details. A blueprint is all-or-nothing: Render validates and prices **every** service in the file before creating any of them, and `render.yaml` asks for a paid database and three paid services.

A second blueprint, `render-free.yaml`, was written for the free tier — free database, no cron services, object storage off. It is committed and valid. The card prompt persisted anyway, so the blueprint route was abandoned in favour of creating the services by hand, which sidesteps whole-file pricing entirely.

If you return to the blueprint route

`render-free.yaml` is ready to use. Point the **Blueprint Path** field at it — the field defaults to `render.yaml`, which is the paid one and will be billed.

4. The route that worked: services by hand

4.1 Database — New > Postgres

Field	Value
Name	servorabd-db
Region	Singapore
PostgreSQL Version	18
Compute	\$0 / month (Free) — the form defaults to a paid row

Selecting the free compute row also removes the separate storage charge. The total at the bottom of the form should read \$0 / month before creating.

4.2 API — New > Web Service

Field	Value
Name	servorabd-api
Language	Python 3
Region	Singapore — must match the database
Root Directory	backend
Instance Type	Free
Health Check Path	/healthz/

Build command:

```
pip install -r requirements.txt \
  && python manage.py collectstatic --no-input \
  && python manage.py migrate
```

Start command — the `../` resolves because Root Directory is backend:

```
gunicorn --config ../deploy/gunicorn.conf.py
```

Eight environment variables, which is the whole set needed to boot:

```
DJANGO_SETTINGS_MODULE = config.settings.prod
PYTHON_VERSION          = 3.12.7
WEB_CONCURRENCY         = 1
DEBUG                   = False
USE_OBJECT_STORAGE      = False
TRUSTED_PROXY_COUNT     = 1
DATABASE_URL            = <Internal Database URL>
SECRET_KEY              = <Generate>
```

Internal, not External: the internal address resolves only inside Render's network, which is what you want between two services in the same region.

4.3 Front end — New > Static Site

Field	Value
Name	servorabd-web
Root Directory	frontend
Build Command	npm ci && npm run build
Publish Directory	dist — relative to Root Directory, so not frontend/dist
Environment Variables	None. Nothing in src/ reads one; the API is called at the relative path /api/v1.

4.4 The five rewrites

Added under **Redirects/Rewrites** on the static site. Without these the landing page loads but every deep link 404s and no data ever arrives.

Source	Destination	Action
/api/*	https://servorabd-api.onrender.com/api/*	Rewrite
/admin/*	https://servorabd-api.onrender.com/admin/*	Rewrite
/static/*	https://servorabd-api.onrender.com/static/*	Rewrite
/	/index.html	Rewrite
/*	/app.html	Rewrite

Order matters: /* is a catch-all and swallows anything listed below it. The action must be **Rewrite**, not Redirect — a redirect changes the browser's address bar and breaks the single-origin arrangement.

4.5 Seeding

Free web services have no shell, so these were run locally against the **External** connection string, from backend/ with the virtual environment active:

```
$env:DATABASE_URL = "<External Database URL>"
$env:DJANGO_SETTINGS_MODULE = "config.settings.prod"
$env:SECRET_KEY = "one-off"
python manage.py seed_catalogue      # 8 categories, 45 services,
                                     # 38 locations
python manage.py createsuperuser
```

createsuperuser does not ask for a name

The user model has `REQUIRED_FIELDS = []` and `full_name` is `blank=True`, so the admin account is created with an empty name and the site header shows nothing. Accounts made through the normal registration form are unaffected. Fix it in `/admin/ > Users`, or with `manage.py shell`.

5. How it was verified

5.1 Before deploying, locally

- Production settings load with only the variables Render sets by itself — no SMTP, no bucket, no `.env` file — which is the state of a first deploy. This is the check that caught the crash in 2.1.
- Booted under `config.settings.prod` against a real PostgreSQL database: `/healthz/` returned ok and `/api/v1/categories/` returned its rows.
- `check --deploy --fail-level WARNING` clean both bare and fully configured.
- `collectstatic` writes through WhiteNoise to local disk even with object storage on, so the build step needs no bucket credentials.
- `gunicorn.conf.py` resolves from `rootDir`: backend and binds to `$PORT`.
- The frontend build emits both `index.html` and `app.html`.
- The full backend test suite passes.

5.2 After deploying, against the live site

Check	Result
<code>/healthz/</code>	<code>{"status": "ok", "database": "ok"}</code>
<code>/</code>	200, landing page
<code>/providers</code>	200, served from <code>app.html</code>
<code>/services</code>	200
<code>/admin/login/</code>	200, styled
Hashed admin CSS	200 — proves WhiteNoise's manifest storage works
<code>/api/v1/categories/</code>	8 categories through the rewrite
<code>/api/v1/locations/</code>	38 locations

6. What is still outstanding

6.1 Two things to act on

Rotate the database password

The External Database URL — user, password and host — was shown in a screenshot during the deployment session. Treat it as disclosed. In Render: **servorabd-db > Settings**, reset the password, then update DATABASE_URL on the API service.

Set a reminder for the 30-day expiry

The free database is deleted 30 days after creation. It cannot be extended, and cannot be upgraded in place — you create a paid one and copy the data across. There is no backup on the free plan, so once it is gone the data is gone.

6.2 Working as designed, but limited

Limitation	Consequence
No SMTP configured	Login codes are e-mailed, so nobody can register or log in . Browsing works; the admin account is unaffected because it is password-based. Set EMAIL_HOST, EMAIL_HOST_USER, EMAIL_HOST_PASSWORD and DEFAULT_FROM_EMAIL to switch the mail backend on.
No cron services on free	The seven scheduled jobs never run: bookings do not auto-expire, reviews do not reveal after 14 days, trust scores do not recompute. Run them by hand with <code>manage.py run_scheduled_jobs</code> .
No persistent disk	Uploads are written to the container filesystem, which is wiped on every deploy and every wake-from-sleep.
Service sleeps after 15 minutes	The first visit after a quiet period takes roughly 50 seconds. Open the site a minute before showing it to anyone.

6.3 Moving to paid

`render.yaml` already describes the paid arrangement: a database with no expiry and daily backups, a service that never sleeps, two cron services, and object storage for uploads. Take a copy of the data first, while the free database still exists:

```
pg_dump --format=custom --no-owner \
  --dbname="<External Database URL>" \
  --file=servorabd.dump
```

`deploy/RENDER.md` covers the paid route in full, including the object storage bucket and the rate-limiting check that needs a live deployment.

6.4 One check worth doing

Rate limits identify a caller by IP address, read from X-Forwarded-For, trusting as many entries as TRUSTED_PROXY_COUNT says. Too high a number and a forged header buys a fresh allowance on every request. It is set to 1, correct for a single Render proxy, but unconfirmed against a live deployment. To check, set

EXPOSE_CLIENT_IDENT=True, wait for the redeploy, then run locally and set it back to False afterwards:

```
python manage.py check_proxy_count \
    https://servorabd-api.onrender.com/api/v1/categories/
```

6.5 Updating the live site

Push to main. Both services rebuild, and the API runs its migrations as part of the build. A failed build leaves the previous version serving, so a broken push does not take the site down.